2024 Voter Registration Evaluation

After every election cycle since 2008, CIRCLE, a third-party research organization, has undertaken a major evaluation of the effectiveness and impact of voter registration activity conducted by hundreds of organizations. This important longitudinal evaluation has enabled the field to standardize metrics and learn from one and another.

The 2024 voter registration evaluation provides powerful evidence for the impact of organizations that conducted voter registration programming in that election cycle. Their work has directly led to millions of new registrants and voters, and it is a key reason why the national voter registration rate is the highest we have seen in decades. Organizations' registration efforts over multiple election cycles also have a growing cumulative impact, and their effectiveness at engaging hard-to-reach communities, like youth and people of color, is necessary to combat persistent gaps and inequities in U.S. democracy.

At the same time, the report reveals that much work remains. Voter registration organizations continue to face challenges—both political barriers like changing election policies and issues like lack of funding and organizational capacity. These challenges are calls to action: to directly support voter registration organizations and to strengthen the legal and political landscape in which organizations are doing their work, in order to unlock the full potential of voter registration programs to expand and diversify the electorate.

The Work in the Field in 2024

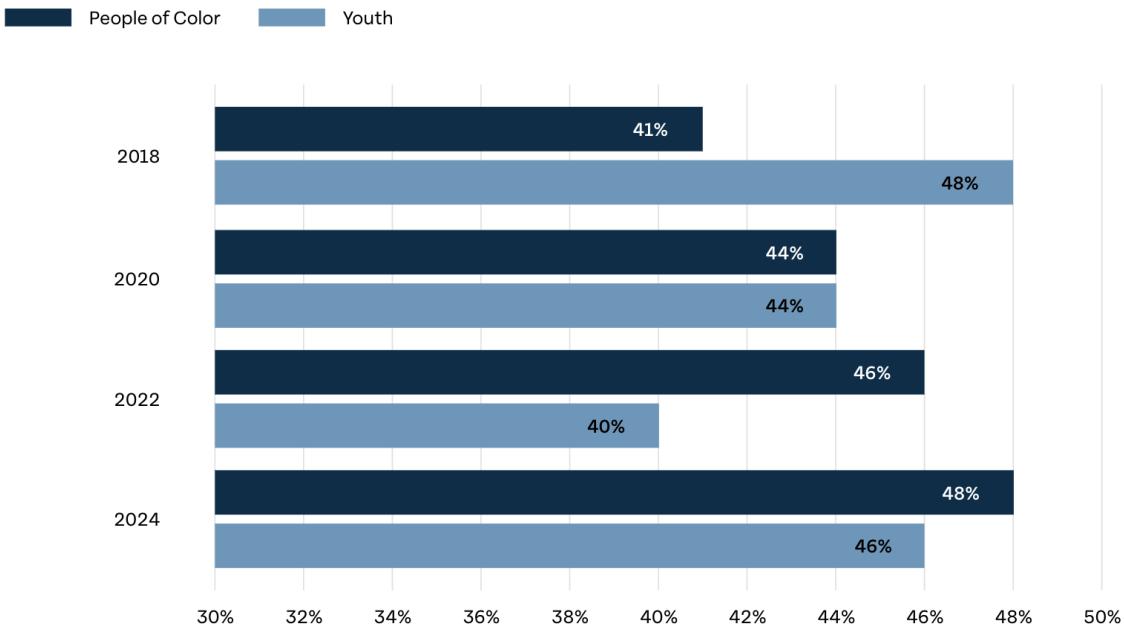
Over 100 organizations participated in the 2024 voter registration evaluation. Those collective efforts had a significant impact: over 6 million voter registration applications were collected in the cycle. These organizations vary in scope—from neighborhood groups to major national organizations—in the tactics they employ, and in their geographic focus. This level of activity is a significant increase from the 2022 election.

Organizations use a variety of tactics to register voters. In 2024, field (in-person registration, door-to-door, or at a high-traffic location) and mail programming produced voter registration applications at similar levels to other recent presidential elections. On the other hand, online voter registration activity decreased compared to 2020.

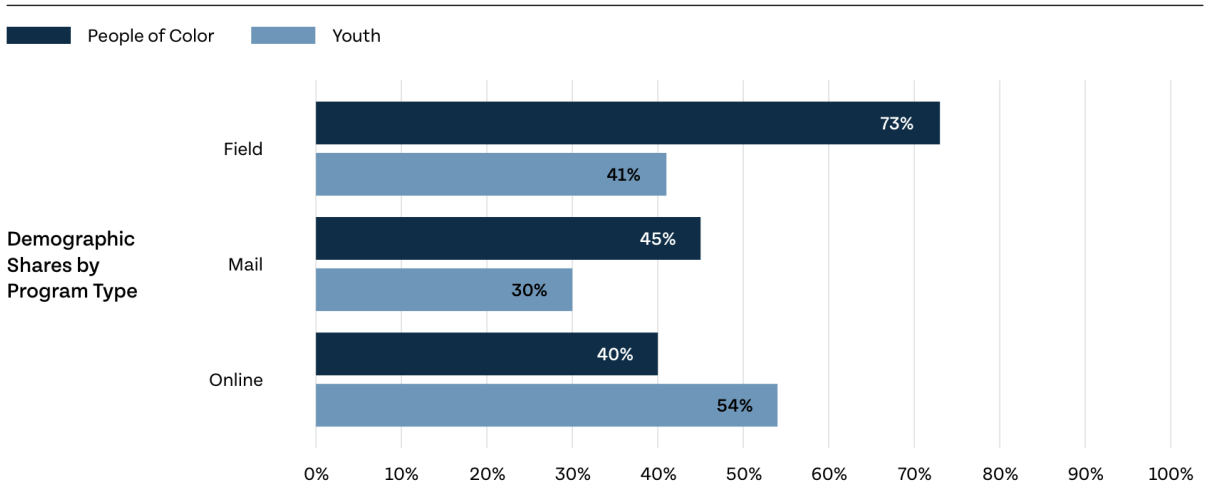
The voter registration evaluation looks at not just inputs (voter registration applications collected by organizations), but also outcomes: whether or not that applicant is actually added to the voting rolls, and if they were a "roll-changing" registrant. Approximately 3.2 million registrants were "roll-changing," meaning they were added to the rolls for the first time or made a necessary update to their name or address.

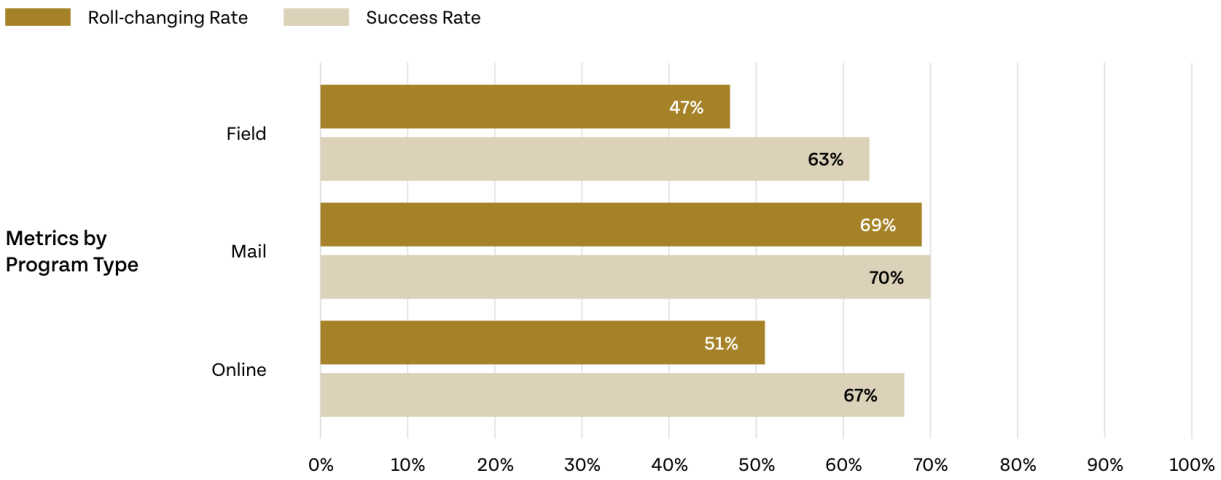
Organizations registering voters are effectively reaching youth and people of color. Among people registered by organizations that participated in this evaluation, they were much more likely to be from groups that have historically had lower rates of participation. The voting-eligible population of the country is 34% people of color, but the registrants from the 2024 cycle were 48% people of color. Additionally, 20% of the VEP is under the age of 30, but 46% of the registrants were.

Figure 27: Share of Registrants from Underrepresented Groups (2018–2024)



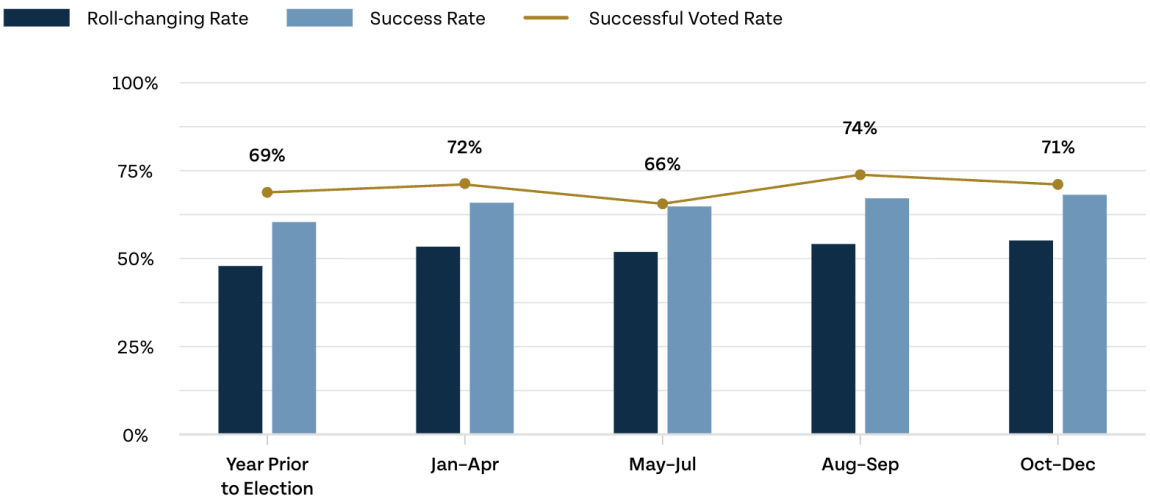
Each voter registration tactic ("program type") used by organizations has pros and cons. Field registrants have lower voting rates but reach more people of color; online programs are larger but reach fewer racially diverse registrants; mail programs are smaller but have the highest yield rate. Though smaller in scale, relational online programs have the highest success rates and are more effective at reaching youth and people of color, highlighting the continued importance of personal connections.





Early registration activity pays dividends. As has been the case in evaluations from previous cycles, the 2024 report found that people registered early in the election cycle get on the voting rolls at similar rates to those registered later: 71% of people registered in the first quarter of 2024 successfully got on the voter file, the same rate as people registered in August or September. Additionally, people registered early in the cycle vote at similar rates to those registered closer to Election Day: 72% of those registered in the first quarter voted, and 74% of people registered in August and September did.

Figure 38: Voting Metrics by Registration Timeframe



In 2024, the share of registrants who voted dropped from the record-high voter turnout rates in 2020, but the registration activity still yielded 3.2 million ballots cast, more than the national margin of victory in the presidential election. This is consistent with the fact that national turnout rates dropped by 1.5 percentage points. This was also corroborated by qualitative analyses, where organizations reported major challenges throughout the 2024 cycle: a difficult political environment—often leading to voter apathy or disengagement—along with funding delays and unpredictability.

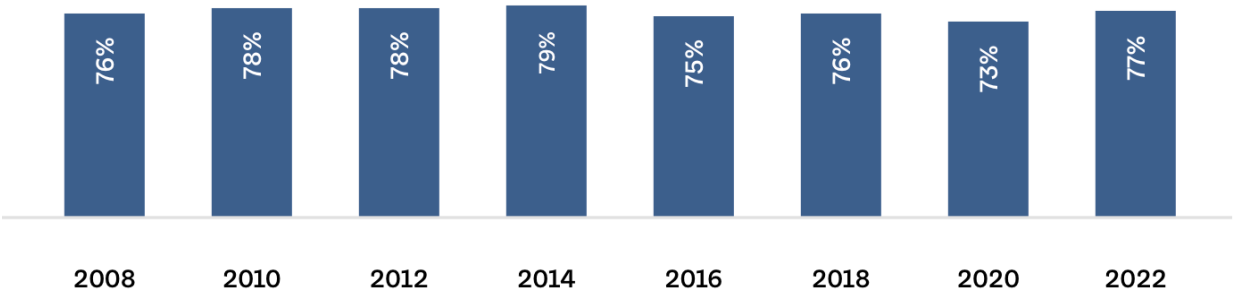
The voter registration evaluation also included insights from organizations on the challenges they faced in 2024 and some of their strategies to overcome them. As in most election cycles, changes to election laws and regulations also presented difficulties for voter registration work. The return to more field programming after the 2020 cycle, which was shaped by COVID-19 pandemic restrictions that eliminated many in-person efforts, presented both barriers and opportunities. It required a challenging scale-up of staff and renewed investments in training and development, but also allowed for leveraging events and positioning outreach in social and cultural spaces. Technological advancements like field-online integration, mapping tools, tablet-based registration, and QR codes helped make programming more effective and efficient.

Long-Term Impact

The voter registration evaluation has collected data going back to the 2008 election cycle. This extensive longitudinal database reveals that approximately 11.6 million people registered by participating organizations cast ballots in the 2024 election, representing more than 7% of all votes cast.

Additionally, it shows that voter registration activity has downstream effects in netting votes year after year. More than 75% of individuals registered by organizations in the 2008-2018 election cycles voted in 2024. About a third of all registrants added to the rolls between 2008-2020 voted in all three of the most recent general elections (2020, 2022, and 2024), and more than half have voted in two out of those three cycles, which suggests that voter registration can create habitual voters.

2024 Voting Rates by Cohort



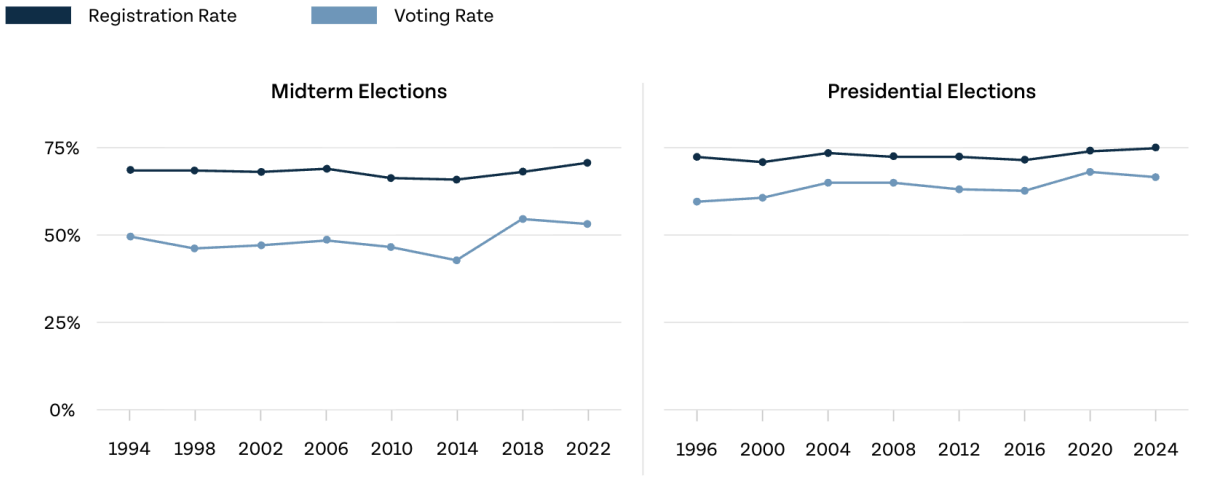
For individuals who were retained on the voter file in 2024, the % who voted in 2024.

The 2024 Voter Registration Landscape

Additional analyses in the 2024 voter registration evaluation used publicly available information to understand national voter registration and turnout trends, as well as the policy landscape that shapes voter registration work.

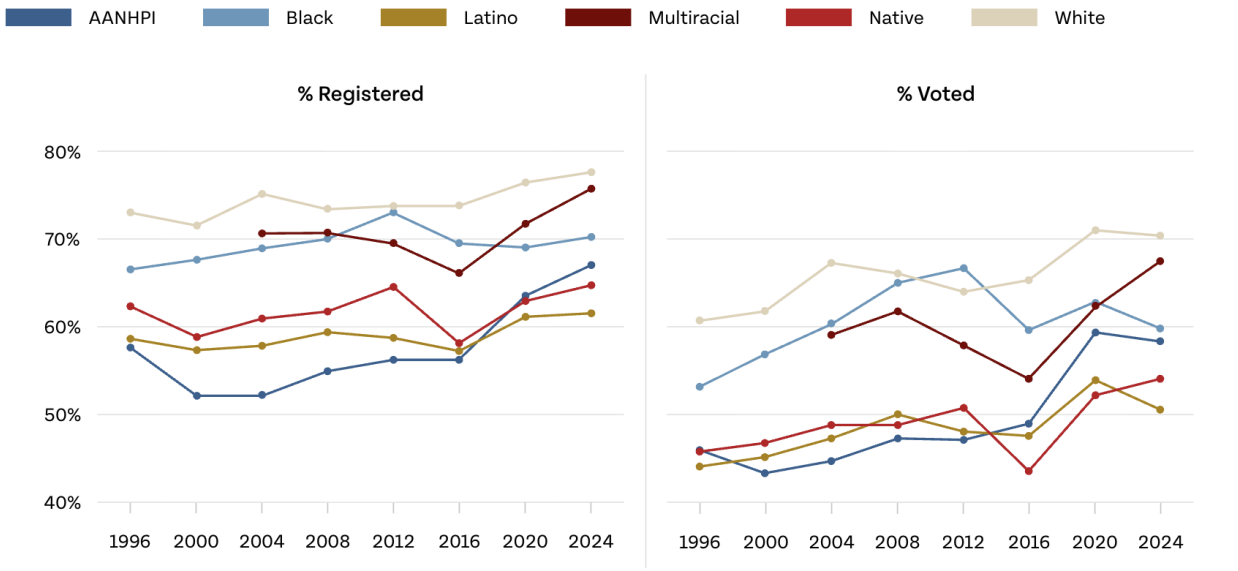
The national voter registration rate is the highest it has been since at least 1994: 73.6%. In part due to the success of voter registration efforts in previous cycles, as well as policy changes that have expanded voter registration opportunities, this means there were fewer unregistered people for partners to reach ahead of the 2024 election. The national voter turnout rate (the percentage of all eligible voters who cast a ballot) was 65.3%, a small 1.5-point decrease from the historic 2020 cycle, but otherwise the highest in the past three decades.

Figure 1: Registration and Voting Rates in Presidential and Midterm Elections (All Voters)



These national trends were also reflected among particular subgroups, with a few notable exceptions. The voter registration rate of every racial/ethnic group increased in 2024 compared to 2020, with the highest increases among AANHPI (Asian American, Native Hawaiian, and Pacific Islander) and multiracial people. The voter turnout rates of most racial/ethnic groups decreased compared to 2020, except for multiracial and Native American voters. Black and Latino voters experienced the largest decreases.

Figure 3: Percent Registered and Voted in Presidential Elections by Race/Ethnicity



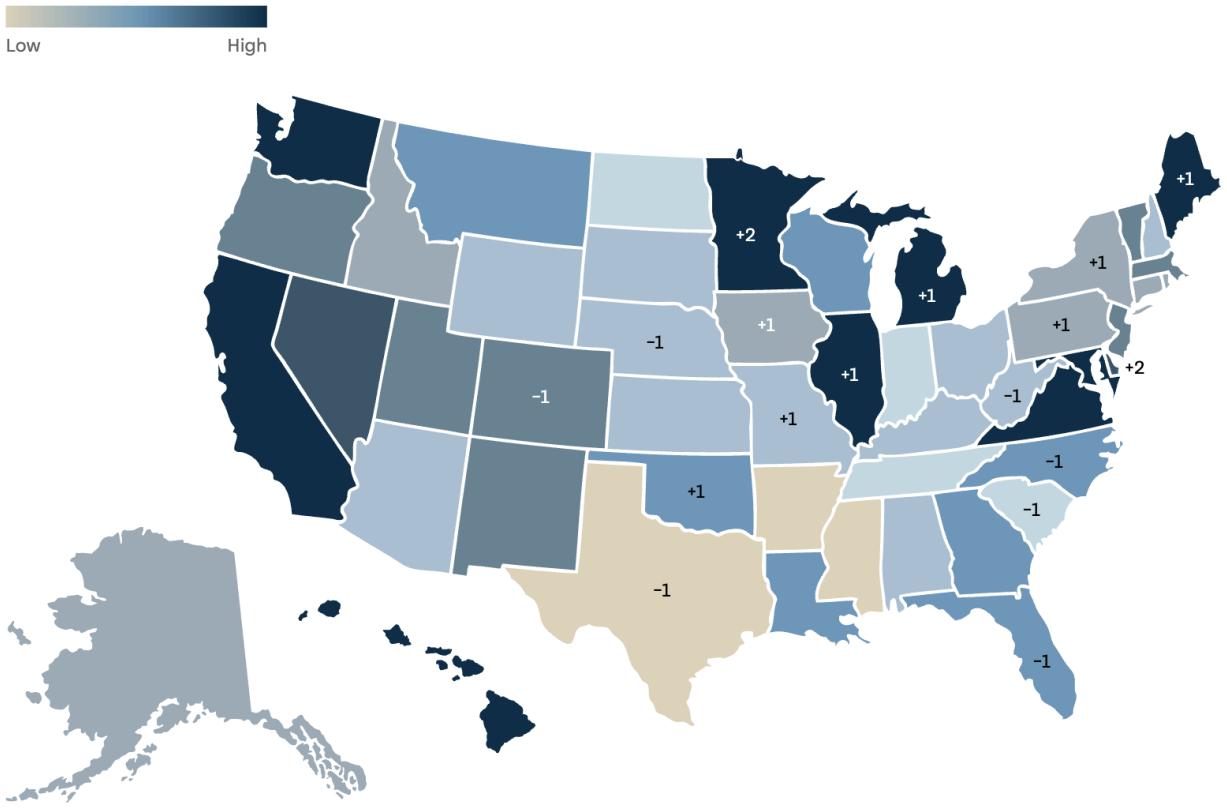
The youngest eligible voters (ages 18-24) continue to have the lowest voter registration and turnout rates; their registration rate decreased 1.5 percentage points compared to 2020. After several election cycles in which the voter registration and turnout gaps between the oldest and

youngest voters had narrowed, those gaps widened again in 2024. The registration rates of people without a Bachelor's degree and of individuals who did not finish high school decreased from 2020 to 2024, and the voter turnout of people without any college experience decreased the most. This widened the voter engagement gap between “college” and “non-college” potential voters to its highest level in the past 30 years.

The election policy landscape remains highly unequal. The majority of states now have Online Voter Registration (OVR), but only about half have Automatic Voter Registration (AVR) or Same-Day Registration (SDR). Even fewer (19 states and Washington, D.C.) have pre-registration for 16- and 17-year-olds, and 15 states have strict photo-ID requirements. Most policy changes ahead of the 2024 cycle were positive: Minnesota and Pennsylvania implemented AVR; Delaware added SDR; Illinois, Michigan, and Minnesota implemented pre-registration; and Alabama, Minnesota, and New Mexico created permanent lists for receiving absentee ballots. In other states, policies made it harder to register and vote: Georgia eliminated its permanent absentee ballot list, and five states (Florida, Nebraska, South Carolina, Ohio, and Wyoming) introduced new strict photo-ID requirements).

2024 Facilitative Registration and Voting Policy Scores

Registration and voting are easier in states with higher scores, and harder in states with lower scores. Positive numbers show improvements in scores since 2022, while negative numbers show declines in scores since 2022.



Implications for 2026 Programming

Based on the findings of this analysis, there are a few considerations for voter registration programming in 2026.

1. **Don't wait to start registering voters**

   Early voter registration programs have high rates of success. Getting started earlier also allows field programs to ramp up while ensuring quality.

2. **Weigh the benefits of different types of programming**

   Field programming is helpful to find people of color, but it does entail more logistical considerations. Online programming can be scaled, but it is harder to target under-engaged people. And mail programs can find people who most need registration, if done using carefully cultivated data sources.

3. **Be aware of changing laws and landscapes**

   While this is always the case, voter registration and engagement activity is subject to changing policies. This may be especially relevant in 2026, given proposed changes to state and national voting laws. Ensure that programs are in compliance and develop high-quality training programs to build confidence in your team.

4. **Pilot new strategies alongside tried-and-true tactics**

   There are new technologies and tactics available to organizations. These may increase efficiency or take the place of more challenging strategies, but should first be deployed as a pilot to iron out the kinks and ensure they can be used successfully as a complement to programs that are established and proven.